It's a simple fact that cricket at Affies did not engage the same scale of emotions or draw the same crowds as rugby, but it's also true that the school excelled at the summer game, leading the extraordinary development of cricket in Afrikaans schools across the country since the mid-1990s.

Most of the credit for this remarkable progress should go to Deon Botes, who coached the Under-15A team when he arrived at Affies in 1998 and has been guiding the 1st XI since 1999. Knowledgeable and dedicated, he has encouraged and inspired generations of young cricketers. It was he who ensured we were regularly invited by Maritzburg College to play at the highly rated Michaelmas cricket week and it was he who, season after season, organised fixtures for us against the likes of Hilton College, Durban High School, Michaelhouse and Grey College, Bloemfontein.

The opportunities to play these schools, to be tested at this level, as much as anything, made it possible for the likes of Jacques Rudolph, Faf du Plessis, Heino Kühn and me to realise our potential.

Carel Kriek was also involved in cricket at the school; it was he who had the foresight to bring in top-quality professional coaches such as Dennis Lindsay, the famously agile South African wicketkeeper between 1963 and 1970 and the man who, among all those who have ever kept wicket in 10 or more Test matches, conceded the fewest byes per Test.

'Hey, Du Plessis and De Villiers, what do you think you're doing?'

An afternoon cricket practice at Affies had just started, and it was Mr Lindsay shouting at us.

'Nothing, sir,' Faf and I replied in unison, as we continued jogging around the field in the warm-up.

'Nothing? That's not what I call nothing. You came late for practice. Now you're tripping each other. You're throwing stones at each other. You're fooling around. Go away. Leave immediately.'

'But sir …'

'Just go away, now.'